

WHAT TO DO, STEP BY STEP

When someone is detained by U.S. immigration

FREE

NO SIGN-UP

EN · ES · RU

● ZERO-DATA

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Information updated July 28, 2026. Rules change — check the date.

We are not attorneys and we do not give legal advice. Only facts and links to official sources. What applies to a specific case is for an attorney to determine.

How to find him

This page on the site — with tools and search:

<https://detnav.com/en/where-is-he/>

The official system does the search. We explain how to use it and what the result means.

What you need

- The A-Number — the letter A and nine digits
- Or: first and last name, country of birth, date of birth

The name must match letter for letter

Many people find someone only on the third or fourth try: a different name order, a second surname, a different transliteration.

The tool below builds spelling variants. Everything stays in this browser.

→ **Open the official locator**

<https://locator.ice.gov>

Empty does not mean he is not there

Records are entered with a delay: the system itself warns that a person may appear up to 72 hours after the arrest.

An empty result in the first hours is common.

What the result means

- **In Custody** — found: the facility is shown, and visits and calls become concrete
- **Not in Custody** — released or deported within the last 60 days
- Empty — not found: a record update takes 20 minutes to 8 hours, plus initial processing at an ICE office of about a day

When the system will not show him

- In the first hours with the border agency a person is not visible; people held by CBP longer than 48 hours do appear in this same locator

- Minors do not appear in this locator
- During a transfer the record can disappear for several days

People are moved between states

Families are not notified. Someone can be flown across the country without warning, and the facility changes on its own.

Check again even if you found him yesterday.

If the search finds nothing

ICE office: where to go and where to check in

If the person has been ordered to check in (ankle monitor, ISAP) or you need to know which office covers the area, find the nearest office by city or state.

→ **All ICE detention facilities — addresses by state**

<https://detnav.com/en/detention/>

The first call

This page on the site — with tools and search:

<https://detnav.com/en/first-call/>

The call is recorded

Calls from the facility are recorded and monitored. Registered attorney lines are the exception.

Before the call

Turn off blocking of unknown numbers

He calls, and the phone silently rejects it — the most painful failure of all. The call will come from an unfamiliar number.

iPhone: Settings → Phone → turn off "Silence Unknown Callers".

Android: Phone app → settings → blocked numbers.

Also check the spam filter with your carrier.

What to ask — you can read this aloud

- Tell me the full A-Number, one digit at a time
- What exactly is the facility called and what city is it in
- Did you sign anything? What exactly?
- Do you need medication?
- How do I put money on the phone account

What this line should not touch

Past removals and orders. Arrests and convictions. Case details and defense plans.

The recording can be used. Those things are discussed with an attorney.

The card to learn by heart and carry on paper

LEARN AND COPY ONTO PAPER

9233#

Dialing 9233# is free from inside the facility — it connects to the nonprofit help line. It works when the account is at zero.

Then, in order: the number of a trusted person · the number of an attorney or organization · 1-888-351-4024 (DRIL, the official ICE line).

The phone is taken first. A slip of paper in a wallet or pocket is the only thing that stays with the person.

- Copy the numbers onto paper by hand — the phone does not go inside
- Add the number of the trusted person and of the attorney once chosen
- Keep one copy in the wallet and one at home; give copies to those close to you
- If there is no attorney yet — 9233# reaches the nonprofit line, where you can ask where to look for free help

Before you call

Keep paper and a pen next to you. There will be little time and you may not get to repeat a question.

→ **Calls, money, letters**

<https://detnav.com/en/staying-in-touch/>

How to reach the person

This page on the site — with tools and search:

<https://detnav.com/en/staying-in-touch/>

The key rule: he can call you. You cannot call him. Below, step by step — calls, messages, video, money, and letters.

Where to start

- 1 Find out which phone provider your facility uses.
- 2 On your own phone, turn off blocking of unknown numbers — otherwise he cannot get through.
- 3 Set up an account and put a little money on it.

1 · Calls

He calls out from the phones in the housing unit. You cannot call him — only he can call you. With no money on the account, there are no calls at all.

How to turn on calls

- 1 Find the facility's provider — most often it is **GettingOut** (the ViaPath company); some use **Securus** or **ICSolutions**.
- 2 Open the provider's website in a browser (or its app) and create an account.
- 3 Link the account by **A-Number** and facility.
- 4 Choose how: fund his personal account — he calls anyone; or link it to your number (AdvancePay) — he calls only you, usually cheaper.
- 5 Put a little on it — the minimum is usually **\$10**. If he is transferred to another facility, the money does not move with him.

→ **GettingOut website — account for calls and messages (the app is there too)**

<https://www.gettingout.com>

→ **Securus website — if the facility uses Securus**

<https://securustech.net>

→ **ICSolutions website — if the facility uses ICSolutions**

<https://www.icsolutions.com>

9233# — free and not monitored

Dialing **9233#** from a facility phone reaches the free Freedom for Immigrants line. Regular calls are recorded; ICE does not monitor this one.

Volunteers speak many languages, help, and can notify your family of where the person is. Hours: Mon–Fri, 8 a.m.–8 p.m. Pacific.

A regular call is recorded and time-limited (about 15–20 minutes). The price is around 7 cents a minute domestically, more for international; it varies by facility. Saying the A-Number on the phone is safe; case details are not. The free-call program some facilities had was ended by ICE in 2026 — expect calls to be paid.

→ **The first call: how to unblock numbers**

<https://detnav.com/en/first-call/>

2 · Messages (text)

These are not regular texts to a phone. They are messages inside the provider’s system — he reads them on a tablet.

How to send

- 1 The same provider and the same account as for calls.
- 2 Open the “Messages” section on the provider’s website.
- 3 Pay for “stamps” (credits) — on the website, by phone, or in the app, minimum usually **\$10**.
- 4 The same funds let you send a photo and a 30-second video message.

Tablets are not in every facility. Delivery is delayed, and everything is screened.

3 · Video calls

Some facilities have video calls — scheduled in advance, through the provider’s website or a kiosk in the lobby. Paid, and the account is needed in advance.

This is not an in-person visit — it has its own rules and hours.

→ **Visiting**

<https://detnav.com/en/visiting/>

4 · Money for daily needs (inside)

This is a separate account — not the one for calls. From it the person buys food, hygiene, and sometimes phone time inside. It is often a different vendor.

How to deposit

- 1 Find the money instructions on this facility's ICE page (the commissary / trust account section) — the details differ by facility.
- 2 The methods, whichever exist — depends on the place: online by card with the vendor (Access Corrections , TouchPay , ViaPath/ConnectNetwork , Western Union); by phone with the vendor; by mail with a money order to the facility's address; in person at a kiosk in the lobby.
- 3 All of them need the full name and A-Number (often the date of birth too).
- 4 Deposit only with the vendor listed for this facility. After a transfer the money gets stuck and is hard to get back.

If there is no one to help

The Freedom for Immigrants Commissary Fund puts money on the account for people who have no one.

Money for daily needs cannot be withdrawn as cash — it is only spent inside.

5 · Letters and postcards

- A plain postcard by mail arrives more reliably than any service
- The A-Number goes on the envelope and on every item, always
- Books — only new and directly from a store or publisher, not from a private person
- Softcover passes faster: hardcover is checked longer and often not allowed
- Every facility has its own rules — confirm by phone before sending

Regular warm contact is what protects the person inside the most.

A plan in case of detention

This page on the site — with tools and search:

<https://detnav.com/en/family-plan/>

Fill it in by hand on paper and keep it at home, so your family knows what to do in the first hour. Nothing is entered online.

Why on paper, not in an app

In the first hour after a detention, the household is in a panic and simple things slip away — whose phone number, where the papers are, who picks up the kids. A sheet filled in ahead of time answers those questions at once.

We deliberately do not make this an online form: no server, ours included, should see this data. It is a family memo, not a questionnaire.

Print this page, fill it in by hand, and put it where your family will find it. Update it every few months.

WHO TO CALL FIRST

Trusted person — who and phone _____

Second person, if the first is unreachable _____

Attorney or organization — name and phone _____

CHILDREN

Who picks the children up from school or daycare _____

That person's phone _____

Where the children's documents are _____

HOME AND DAILY LIFE

Where the important papers are (passports, contracts) _____

Who pays the rent while I am away _____

Who cares for the pet _____

HEALTH

Medicines I take, and where they are _____

Conditions people should know about _____

WHAT TO KNOW BY HEART

The trusted person's phone — memorize it, don't only write it down _____

The code for a free call to the DHS OIG complaint line from detention: 9233# _____

Build a personal task list — in advance

A two-minute survey assembles a task list for the family's circumstances — both for a detention and for preparing ahead. Answers stay in the browser. Print the finished list and keep it with this plan.

→ **Take the survey and get the task list**

<https://detnav.com/en/your-list/>

Give the plan to a trusted person — today

Hand the filled-in plan and the assembled document packet to someone you trust, ahead of time. Then they start acting the moment you are detained, instead of losing a day figuring out what happened.

Agree on a simple signal: every evening you send them one word that all is well. Two evenings missed in a row — they start with the steps below.

What the trusted person does if you go silent

- 1 Finds you through the ICE locator — by name and country of birth, or by the A-Number from the plan.

- 2 Calls the attorney or organization whose numbers are written in the plan above.
- 3 Signs nothing for you and pays no one without checking first.
- 4 Gives the attorney the document packet you handed over in advance.

Money and property: it works only if done in advance

While a person is in detention, the rent, the car loan and the bank account do not pause. Loved ones can act for them legally only with papers signed ahead of time — they cannot be made after the fact.

Financial power of attorney (durable POA)

A notarized durable financial power of attorney naming a trusted person lets them legally end a lease, collect belongings, deal with the bank, and sell a car. Without it, the landlord and the bank do not even have to talk to them.

It is signed before a notary in advance. Which powers to include is a question for an attorney: the wording depends on the state.

The bank account

Login verification tied only to SMS stops working once the phone is confiscated or the number is cut off. Bank settings usually allow adding e-mail verification — keeping access to a mailbox is easier.

Many banks accept a power of attorney only on their own form and only in person. Visiting a branch together with the trusted person ahead of time removes that barrier.

The rented home and belongings

An apartment left unpaid turns into debt: lease-break fees, collectors, and the belongings go to storage or the curb. A person holding a power of attorney can end the lease by the rules and collect the things.

A financed or leased car

A car with missed payments gets repossessed by the lender and sold at auction. The remaining balance stays with the owner, and the forgiven part may be counted as taxable income (Form 1099-C).

The legal paths that exist: a power of attorney with authority to sell the vehicle, or an official transfer of the loan or lease to another person. The terms are in the contract and with the lender.

Retirement accounts: 401(k) and IRA

Savings in a 401(k) or IRA remain the person's property regardless of immigration status or deportation — they do not burn up.

Withdrawing before age 59½ usually carries a 10% IRS penalty plus taxes, which is why accounts are often left to grow until retirement age. From abroad, tax status is certified with Form W-8BEN. What to do with a specific account is a question for a tax adviser.

→ **Form W-8BEN — official IRS page**

<https://www.irs.gov/forms-pubs/about-form-w-8-ben>

Three tasks for this week

- 1 Switch the bank login verification from SMS to e-mail, or add e-mail as a backup method.
- 2 Sign a financial power of attorney before a notary and register it at the bank in person.
- 3 Put scans of the SSN/ITIN, the lease and loan contracts and the car papers into encrypted storage, and give the trusted person access.

This is a map, not legal advice

What to include in the power of attorney, how to end a lease, and what to do with a retirement account depend on the state and on the contract. Those decisions are made with an attorney and a tax adviser, not from an internet memo.

What to carry with you

The filled-in plan stays home. On you — only the small rights card. Take a photo of the card and keep it on your phone.

RIGHTS CARD · CARRY WITH YOU

I do not want to talk, answer questions, or sign documents without a lawyer. I do not consent to entry into my home without a judicial warrant signed by a judge.

No quiero hablar, responder preguntas ni firmar documentos sin un abogado. No doy consentimiento para entrar a mi casa sin una orden judicial firmada por un juez.

Я не хочу говорить, отвечать на вопросы и подписывать документы без адвоката. Я не даю согласия войти в дом без судебного ордера, подписанного судьёй.

Do not carry the plan with names and phones on you

If it is found during a detention, it holds the names and addresses of your loved ones. The plan stays home; only the rights card goes in your pocket.

“What To Do, Step by Step” — a PDF to print and share

The key sections of the site in one file: the first night, this plan, the rights card, calls and money, the road, habeas, the glossary — with every link. Send the file to your family and print a copy for home.

→ **Download “What To Do, Step by Step” (PDF, ~25 pages)**

</playbook/detnav-playbook-en.pdf>

→ **Assemble the document packet for the attorney**

<https://detnav.com/en/attorney-package/>

→ **What the papers mean and what not to sign**

<https://detnav.com/en/what-papers-mean/>

→ **If someone is already detained — where to start**

<https://detnav.com/en/your-list/>

The road

This page on the site — with tools and search:

<https://detnav.com/en/the-road/>

Twelve steps after the person is found. This is not your plan — it is a map of the process: we show every step that exists. Seven are open, the rest are in the works.

1 Found · where he is

The facility, the state, the circuit. From here everything becomes concrete.

2 Staying in touch

The phone account, letters and postcards, books. Why you cannot call in.

3 Visiting

Hours, how to sign up, documents, what cannot be brought in.

4 Attorney

Free, accredited representative, paid. You can search by language.

5 How attorney money is counted

Rates, phases, the retainer, what belongs in the agreement.

6 Documents

A queue of tasks, one at a time. Phone photos — a clean PDF for the attorney.

7 Release paths

Which mechanisms exist and what works now. The first question for the attorney.

8 Habeas corpus · federal court

The path release is most often won through now. An attorney prepares and files it.

9 Released · what now

Check-ins, electronic monitoring, change of address. The case continues.

10 The first court hearing

The master calendar hearing and how it differs from the merits hearing.

11 Do not miss

Reminders 14, 3, and 1 day ahead. Form EOIR-33 after a move.

12 The long game

The case runs for months and years. What to keep accumulating all that time.

Parallel tracks

- **Children** — School, medical consent, what to tell the child. In the works.
- **Family money** — Rent, missed wages, the conversation with the employer. In the works.
- **He was transferred** — A transfer resets the attorney and the phone money. What to redo. In the works.
- **Health** — Medications, chronic conditions, access to medical information. In the works.

Unfinished steps are honestly marked "in the works". Seeing the scale of the whole road is useful in itself: the case does not end at release.

Habeas corpus · federal court

This page on the site — with tools and search:

<https://detnav.com/en/habeas-corpus/>

The path release is most often won through now. We explain how it works. An attorney prepares and files the petition — this is a map, not instructions for filing on your own.

What it is

Habeas corpus is a petition to a federal district court: a judge examines whether the government is holding a person lawfully.

It is a different system, not the immigration court. A federal judge does not answer to the agency: the judge can demand explanations from the government, order a release hearing — or order release.

Why everyone is talking about it now

Since 2025 bond and parole are granted very rarely, and the center of gravity has shifted to the federal courts: in February 2026 about 2,000 habeas petitions were filed nationwide every week — a year earlier it was about 20. Federal judges across the spectrum schedule hearings and order releases when the petition is prepared well.

Lawyers of AILA, the immigration attorneys association, put it plainly: for a growing number of detained people, habeas in federal court is in practice the only path to freedom.

As of July 2026. This is the overall picture, not a prediction for a specific case.

Two systems: where bond is decided, and where habeas is

Bond

IMMIGRATION COURT (EOIR)

- Decided by an immigration judge — EOIR is part of the Department of Justice, an agency system
- After the 2025 ICE memo and BIA decisions, broad categories get no bond hearing at all (mandatory detention)
- Even a granted bond does not resolve the removal case — the court process continues

Habeas corpus

FEDERAL DISTRICT COURT

- Decided by an independent federal judge (28 U.S.C. § 2241) — answerable to neither ICE nor EOIR
- Reviews the lawfulness of the detention itself — including where the agency refused bond
- Alongside the petition, the attorney can ask to bar transfer and pause removal (TRO / stay)

The paths do not exclude each other. Which applies to a specific case, and in what order, is for the attorney to determine.

Habeas is about the detention — not a shield against deportation

Filing the petition does not by itself stop a removal. A stay or an emergency order (TRO) is a separate ruling the court makes — the attorney asks for it.

If someone tells you that filing habeas "automatically" protects against deportation, ask the attorney what exactly they are requesting from the court in that case.

How it works

- The petition is filed in the federal district court for the place of detention — which is why it matters so much where the facility is
- A transfer to another state changes the court and the applicable rules — one more reason not to wait
- Together with the petition, the attorney can ask for an emergency court order against transfer or deportation (TRO)
- The judge can schedule a hearing, order release — or deny: the outcome depends on the specific case
- An attorney prepares and files the petition — this is work for a lawyer with federal practice

Your part — preparation

- The dossier of ties to the US: address, years of residence, family, work, community — the tasks for it are collected in the questionnaire
- The timeline: when and where the person was detained, when transferred, what papers were issued
- The A-Number and the exact name of the facility
- Medical documents, if there are conditions

→ **Your task list**

<https://detnav.com/en/your-list/>

→ **Assemble the document package for the attorney**

<https://detnav.com/en/attorney-package/>

Questions for the attorney

- Whether habeas fits this case, and why
- Which federal circuit the facility is in and what that changes
- What is needed from the family, and by when
- What changes if the person is transferred to another state

What we do not do

We do not prepare or file petitions and we do not give legal advice. Only an attorney can determine whether this path applies to a specific case.

If anyone other than an attorney with a verified license promises to "file habeas" and win a quick release for money — check them against the registries.

Glossary of terms

This page on the site — with tools and search:

<https://detnav.com/en/glossary/>

Words that show up in papers, phone calls, and conversations with an attorney. Just definitions — what a term means, not what to do about it.

This is a dictionary, not legal advice

The definitions below are general and do not account for a specific case. Some rules differ by state and appellate circuit, and the wording in the law is more precise than this short summary. How a term applies to a particular case is something an attorney determines.

Who is who

ICE

Immigration and Customs Enforcement. An agency of the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) that locates, detains, and removes people without legal status inside the country.

ERO

Enforcement and Removal Operations — the part of ICE that carries out arrests, holds people in custody, and organizes removals.

CBP

Customs and Border Protection. Operates at the border, ports, and airports; a separate agency from ICE.

USCIS

U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services. Processes applications for status — green cards, citizenship, work permits. Does not carry out detentions.

DHS

Department of Homeland Security. The parent agency over ICE, CBP, and USCIS.

EOIR

Executive Office for Immigration Review. Part of the Department of Justice, separate from DHS. Hears removal cases.

Immigration Judge (IJ)

A judge of an EOIR immigration court, appointed by the Department of Justice — not the same thing as a federal judge.

BIA

Board of Immigration Appeals. Hears appeals of an immigration judge's decisions.

Deportation officer, Officer of Record

The ICE ERO officer assigned to a specific detained person's case.

Field office

A regional ICE ERO office covering a given area. See the office finder page.

Detention and status**A-Number, A-file**

A nine-digit number assigned to a person in the immigration system, and the file of documents kept under it. The key to searching ICE and EOIR records.

Detainer (ICE hold)

A request from ICE to a local jail or police department to hold a person for a further period — usually up to 48 hours — past the time they would otherwise be released, so ICE can take custody.

Mandatory detention

Custody with no separate hearing on the possibility of bond, when it applies to a case — for example, under certain criminal grounds ([INA § 236\(c\)](#)).

Bond

A monetary payment that secures a person's release from ICE custody while a case is pending.

Bond hearing

A separate hearing before an immigration judge about the amount of bond, or whether one is set at all.

ATD

Alternatives to Detention — forms of supervision outside a detention facility: an ankle monitor, a check-in app, or scheduled appearances.

ISAP

Intensive Supervision Appearance Program — a private ATD program run under contract with ICE by BI Incorporated.

Check-in

The requirement to periodically report to an ICE office, or check in by phone or app, as part of ATD or after release.

Credible fear interview

An interview with a USCIS officer for a person stopped at the border or re-entering the country, about whether they have a credible fear of persecution at home.

Reasonable fear interview

A similar interview for a person with a prior removal order or certain convictions. The bar to pass it is higher than for credible fear.

The court process

Removal proceedings

The EOIR court process deciding whether a person must leave the United States.

NTA, Notice to Appear (Form I-862)

The document that starts removal proceedings: it lists allegations about the person and the charges.

Master calendar hearing

A short administrative hearing: the judge checks the status of the case, sets the next date, and notes whether the person has an attorney.

Individual hearing (merits hearing)

The main hearing on the merits of the case, where evidence is presented and a decision is made.

Continuance

Postponing a hearing to a later date.

In absentia order

A removal order issued when a person did not appear for a scheduled hearing.

Venue

The EOIR court where a specific case is heard. It can change when a person is transferred between detention facilities.

Docket number

The number under which a case is registered with the court.

Relief and outcomes

Asylum

A form of protection for a person who cannot return home due to persecution based on race, religion, nationality, political opinion, or membership in a particular social group.

Withholding of removal

A narrower protection than asylum: it bars removal to a specific country but does not lead to a green card.

CAT protection

Protection under the Convention Against Torture — from removal to a country where the person would face torture by, or with the consent of, the government.

Cancellation of removal

Cancels a removal order when certain conditions are met. The rules differ for lawful permanent residents (LPRs) and for others.

Voluntary departure

Permission to leave the U.S. on one's own and at one's own expense instead of a forced removal. It can differ from a removal order in its effect on future entry.

Prosecutorial discretion

A decision by ICE or an EOIR prosecutor not to pursue a case further, or to close it, based on agency priorities.

Adjustment of status

Changing status to permanent residence (a green card) without leaving the United States.

Order of removal

The court's final decision that a person must be removed.

Stay of removal

A temporary postponement of carrying out a removal order.

Motion to reopen, motion to reconsider

A request to have a case reviewed again based on new facts or an error in the decision.

Appeal to the BIA

Challenging an immigration judge's decision before the Board of Immigration Appeals.

Habeas corpus

A separate case filed in federal district court — not EOIR — about the lawfulness of the detention itself, under 28 U.S.C. § 2241 . Prepared and filed by an attorney.

Status and documents

LPR, green card

Lawful Permanent Resident — the status of a permanent U.S. resident.

EAD

Employment Authorization Document — a work permit, separate from a green card.

TPS

Temporary Protected Status — a temporary status for nationals of certain countries it is unsafe to return to (natural disaster, armed conflict).

Naturalization

The process of becoming a U.S. citizen.

Sponsor, petitioner

The person or organization filing a petition on behalf of a relative or worker so they can obtain status.

Help organizations by state

Verified nonprofits — legal help and family support. Links are clickable.

California • CHIRLA

Coalition for Humane Immigrant Rights — legal services and family support across California.

<https://www.chir1a.org/>

Texas • RAICES

Nonprofit providing free and low-cost immigration legal aid across Texas.

<https://raicestexas.org/>

Louisiana • LAAID

Louisiana Advocates for Immigrants in Detention — volunteers who help around Louisiana's detention centers: transport, visits, support after release.

<https://laaid.org/>

New York • NYIFUP

New York Immigrant Family Unity Project — publicly funded representation for detained New Yorkers who cannot afford an attorney, explained by the Vera Institute.

<https://www.vera.org/ending-mass-incarceration/reducing-incarceration/detention-of-immigrants/new-york-immigrant-family-unity-project>

Florida • Americans for Immigrant Justice

Immigrant Families Defense Fund — free legal representation at Florida's detention centers.

<https://aijustice.org/defense-fund/>